coursera

Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Learn With PsycLearn Essentials

Module 2
Opening to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Lesson 1: Culture and Mood Disorders
- ✓ Focus of the Course
  Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Classifying Psychopathology
  Reading • 4 min
- ✓ Culture and Psychopathology
  Reading • 4 min
- ✓ Culture and Intersectionality
  Reading • 4 min
- ✓ Culture and Stigma
  Reading • 4 min
- ✓ Check Your Understanding: Culture and Mood Disorders
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%

Lesson 2: Introduction to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
- ✓ Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Video • 6 min
- ✓ Living with a Mood Disorder: A Case Study
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Overview of Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Check Your Understanding: Introduction to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%

Key Takeaways
- ✓ Key Takeaways: Opening to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Reading • 10 min

Module 2 Quiz
- ✓ Module Quiz: Opening to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Graded Assignment • Grade: 87.5%

Module 3
Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Lesson 3: Overview of Depressive Disorders
- ✓ Depression: A Case Study
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ **What Does Depression Feel Like?**
  Reading • 7 min
- ○ Diagnostic Criteria and Prevalence for Depressive Disorders
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ Check Your Understanding: Overview of Depressive Disorders
  Practice Assignment • 12 min

Lesson 4: Overview of Bipolar Disorders
- ○ Bipolar: A Case Study
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ What Does Bipolar Feel Like?
  Reading • 7 min
- ○ Diagnostic Criteria and Prevalence for Bipolar Disorders
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ Check Your Understanding: Overview of Bipolar Disorders
  Practice Assignment • 13 min

Key Takeaways
- ○ Key Takeaways: Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Reading • 10 min

Module 3 Quiz
- ○ Module Quiz: Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Graded Assignment • 16 min

Module 4
Biological Contributing Factors

Module 5
Psychological Contributing Factors

Module 6
Treatments for Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Module 7
Suicide

Module 8
Conclusion

Module 9
Cumulative Quiz

Module 10
Course Resources

Module 11
PsycLearn Essentials APA Student Resources

What Does Depression Feel Like?

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Common Symptoms of Depressive Disorders

More than 300 million people worldwide are impacted by some form of depression (Gerhard, et al., 2016; Ledford, 2014) and, worldwide, depression is the leading cause of disability (World Health Organization, 2023). Most often when someone says they were diagnosed with depression, they are referring to one of the depressive disorders recognized by medical professionals. All depressive disorders share a common set of symptoms:

- **negative mood** (such as sadness);
- **maladaptive cognitions** (such as all-or-none thinking or emotional numbing), and
- **physiological changes** (such as trouble sleeping).

Within the *ICD-11* diagnostic manual, depressive disorders are also identified by the frequency of the episode (i.e., single or recurrent), the severity of the symptoms (i.e., mild, moderate, or severe), and with or without psychotic symptoms. Psychotic symptoms are described as a loss of contact with reality that can include delusions, false beliefs, irrational belief systems, or **hallucinations,** which are false sensory experiences such as hearing voices, or disorganized speech or behavior.

Review the description offered by S. in the case study about their struggles with depression during the pandemic. Did you note that in their description, S. describes experiencing a pervasive feeling of sadness (negative mood), emotional numbing (maladaptive cognition), and difficulty sleeping (physiological change). From their description, S. is exhibiting symptoms of depression, for which they sought professional help.

Depression is a syndrome in the truest sense of the word—it is a collection of related symptoms that form a single clinical presentation. Beyond persistently feeling sad, people with depression experience an array of cognitive, affective, and behavioral symptoms including, disruptions to eating and sleeping, fatigue and lethargy, cognitive distortions, and difficulty concentrating and thinking.

Exhaustion and disengagement with life are symptoms of depression. Life-impairing symptoms such as fatigue, sleep and eating disruptions are also common in depression, but largely absent in people who are merely sad. These symptoms can lead to cognitive difficulties—depressed people have a harder time focusing and making decisions than those without depression. Each of these symptoms can negatively impact people's functioning in their lives, which in turn exacerbates their depression.

People who are depressed may also experience cognitive distortions, which are inaccurate, negative views of themselves and the world. People who are experiencing ordinary sadness can have those same thoughts, however, cognitive distortions are more likely to come and go in people who are sad, whereas people with depression experience them all the time.

Not everyone has all of these symptoms, and so different people with depression can look very different. One person might be eating constantly, feeling emotionally numb, and sleeping all the time, while another may be losing weight without trying, crying constantly, and unable to concentrate.

Psychologists Jonathan Smith and John Rhodes (2015) interviewed patients who had recently experienced their first episode of depression. Hearing their descriptions of the experience offers a window into that experience:

- "It's emptiness…it's being locked away, you just don't care about yourself. It's like part of you [is] gone, your heart, I don't know. Perhaps half my heart has gone away" (p. 202);
- "It's like something's gone inside me and swept my happiness away" (p. 202);
- "During the middle of the day it just got too bad and I just started crying. It was so extreme. I couldn't hold it anymore" (p. 204).

One additional danger of depression is that it is a significant risk factor for suicide (American Psychological Association, 2013). Thoughts of suicide are common in patients with depression. Feelings of emptiness, worthlessness, hopelessness, and depletion are all common elements in the experience of depression.

How Depression and Sadness Differ

Sadness is a normal emotional response when we experience the loss of things that we value such as relationships, financial security, treasured personal items, or when going through a challenging life moment. Bereavement over the loss of a family member, friend, or pet are also expected causes of sadness. In many cases, though, the sadness is directly tied to an event and as time passes, the sadness eases. Indeed sadness is one symptom of depression. However, in depression, the cause of sadness might not be apparent, or there might not be a specific cause for the feeling of sadness. Moreover, for people with depression, these feelings of sadness are persistent, cause distress, and interfere with daily life.

Differentiating everyday sadness from depression can be challenging. However, one key symptom of depression is not often seen in regular sadness. This symptom is **anhedonia**—the inability to enjoy pleasurable activities or experience pleasure. People with depression experience the loss or muting of feelings of pleasure—perhaps the most brutal symptom of depression. People who do not have depression can lift their bad moods by participating in activities they enjoy, listening to music, seeing friends, and so on. People with depression are not able to change their mood in this way. Moreover, people with severe depression not only have a hard time feeling happy, but they also have a hard time remembering having ever felt happy and can't imagine being happy ever again.

To help differentiate depressive episodes from everyday sadness that we all experience, remember two things: First, for a person to be diagnosed with depression they must display related symptoms, which may include difficulty concentrating, feeling hopeless, having thoughts of death or suicide, sleeplessness, fatigue, or changes in appetite but without symptoms of mania, hypomania, or mixed episodes. There are many people who have a single symptom of depression, but who aren't depressed. Second, people who are depressed experience these symptoms more consistently and more intensely than people who are sad but not depressed.

A depressive disorder is characterized by:

- a depressed mood every day for at least two weeks.
- a level of depression that causes difficulty functioning at work, in relationships, or personally.

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